ceremonies of castes or orders which are productive of future reward'. The Charvakas were in fact contemptuous of holy men and their practices: 'The Agnihotra sacrifice, the three Vedas, the mendicant's triple staff (*tridanda*), and the practice of smearing oneself with ashes, are only means of livelihood ordained by the creator for men who have neither understanding nor energy.' And they were also scathing about the theological claims of astika philosophers: 'If [it be true that] an animal slaughtered at the Jyotistoma sacrifice is [in consequence] exalted to heaven', they asked, 'why does the worshipper not immolate his own father?'[2]

Hinduism, in other words, incorporates almost all forms of belief and worship within it; there is no need to choose some or reject others. Mahatma Gandhi famously appreciated this quality of Hinduism: 'Its freedom from dogma makes a forcible appeal to me,' he wrote, 'inasmuch as it gives the votary the largest scope for self-expression.'[3] It is therefore a timeless faith, populated by ideas at once ancient and modern, hosting texts, philosophies, belief systems and schools of thought that do not necessarily all agree with each other. But none has ever been rejected by some supreme authority as beyond the pale; there is no such authority in Hinduism. There can be no Hindu Inquisition because there is neither an exacting theology that everyone must subscribe to as holy writ, nor an exalted authority empowered to appoint an Inquisitor. Hindu thought is like a vast library in which no book ever goes out of print; even if the religious ideas a specific volume contains have not been read, enunciated or followed in centuries, the book remains available to be dipped into, to be revised and reprinted with new annotations or a new commentary whenever a reader feels the need for it. In many cases the thoughts it contains may have been modified by or adapted to other ideas that may have arisen in response; in most, it's simply there, to be referred to, used or ignored as Hindus see fit.

Inevitably, though, the question 'who is a Hindu?' has been asked, and, equally inevitably, political figures have entered the definitional fray. The fighter for Indian independence, 'Lokmanya (accepted by the people)' Bal Gangadhar Tilak (1856–1920), suggested, in a meeting of the Sanatana Dharma Sabha (Association of Hindus), that 'a Hindu is he